

Pi Alert

SIMPLIFIED Setup Guide

No Pi-hole • No Email • Just Network Monitoring

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■ What is Pi Alert?

Pi Alert is a network monitoring tool that shows you ALL devices connected to your WiFi/network. It's like having a security guard watching who connects to your home network!

■ What You'll Get:

- See all devices on your network in real-time
- Get alerts when new devices connect
- Track device history
- Simple web dashboard

■■ NOTE: This guide skips Pi-hole and email setup to keep things simple. You can add those features later if needed!

■ ■ What You Need

Item	Details
Raspberry Pi 4	Any RAM size works (2GB+ recommended)
SD Card	At least 8GB with Raspberry Pi OS installed
Network	Pi connected via Ethernet cable (preferred) or WiFi
Access	SSH enabled OR keyboard + monitor connected
Time	About 15-20 minutes

■ *TIP: Make sure your Raspberry Pi OS is already installed and you can access it. If you need help with that, check out the basic Raspberry Pi setup videos first!*

STEP 1: Update Your Pi

First, let's make sure everything is up to date.

Run this command (it might take a few minutes):

```
sudo apt update && sudo apt upgrade -y
```

■ *TIP: Press ENTER after typing the command. You might be asked for your password. Type it and press ENTER (you won't see the password as you type - that's normal!).*

STEP 2: Install Required Software

Now we'll install everything Pi Alert needs to work.

Copy and paste this ENTIRE command (it's long!):

```
sudo apt install git python3 python3-pip apache2 php php-cli php-sqlite3 php-curl  
php-xml libapache2-mod-php sqlite3 arp-scan curl net-tools -y
```

■■ *This will take 5-10 minutes. You'll see lots of text scrolling. That's normal! Wait until you see the command prompt again.*

STEP 3: Download Pi Alert

Let's download Pi Alert from the internet.

Run these commands one at a time:

```
cd /var/www/html
```

```
sudo git clone https://github.com/pucherot/Pi.Alert.git pialert
```

■ *TIP: If you see 'fatal: destination path 'pialert' already exists', that means Pi Alert is already there. That's okay! Skip to Step 4.*

STEP 4: Set Permissions

Give Pi Alert permission to access the files it needs.

Run these two commands:

```
sudo chown -R www-data:www-data /var/www/html/pialert
```

```
sudo chmod -R 755 /var/www/html/pialert
```

These commands won't show any output - if you just get your command prompt back, it worked!

STEP 5: Run the Installer (IMPORTANT!)

Now we'll run the Pi Alert installer. This is where those confusing questions appear, but DON'T WORRY - I'll tell you exactly what to answer!

Run this command:

```
cd /var/www/html/pialert
sudo ./install/pialert_install.sh
```

■ How to Answer the Questions:

Question	Your Answer	Why
Install Pi-hole?	N (press N then ENTER)	We are skipping Pi-hole to keep it simple
Install Pi-hole?	N	Say no again if asked twice
Email notifications?	N	We are skipping email setup
SMTP settings?	Just press ENTER	Skip all email-related questions
Network interface?	Press ENTER for default	Usually eth0 or wlan0 - default is fine
Scan subnets?	Press ENTER for default	It will auto-detect your network
Install location?	Press ENTER for default	We already put it in the right place

■■ KEY POINT: When in doubt, just press ENTER to accept the default! The only important answers are 'N' for Pi-hole and 'N' for email.

STEP 6: Give Scanning Permissions

Pi Alert needs special permission to scan your network. This is the trickiest part, but follow along carefully!

Run this command:

```
sudo visudo
```

This will open a text editor. It looks scary but it's okay! Follow these steps:

- 1■■ Use arrow keys to scroll to the VERY BOTTOM of the file
- 2■■ Press 'i' (this puts you in INSERT mode - you'll see -- INSERT -- at the bottom)
- 3■■ Press ENTER to make a new line
- 4■■ Type this EXACTLY (or copy-paste):

```
www-data ALL=(ALL) NOPASSWD: /usr/sbin/arp-scan
```

- 5■■ Press ESC key
- 6■■ Type :wq and press ENTER (yes, include the colon!)

■ *TIP: If you mess up, press ESC then type :q! and press ENTER to exit without saving. Then run 'sudo visudo' again to try once more.*

STEP 7: Find Your Pi's IP Address

You need to know your Pi's IP address to access the web interface.

Run this command:

```
hostname -I
```

You'll see something like: 192.168.1.100 or 10.0.0.50

■ **WRITE THIS DOWN! You'll need it in the next step.**

STEP 8: Access Pi Alert!

Now for the exciting part - seeing it work!

- 1■■ Open a web browser on your computer or phone
- 2■■ In the address bar, type:

```
http://YOUR-PI-IP/pialert/
```

Replace YOUR-PI-IP with the IP address from Step 7. For example: <http://192.168.1.100/pialert/>

■ *SUCCESS! You should see the Pi Alert dashboard! It might take a minute or two for the first scan to complete and show your devices.*

STEP 9: Run Your First Scan

Let's manually trigger a scan to see all your devices right now!

Go back to your Pi terminal and run:

```
cd /var/www/html/pialert  
sudo php back/pialert.php 1 updateDevices
```

This will scan your network right now. You'll see a bunch of output - that's good! Wait until it finishes (you'll see the command prompt again).

Now refresh your web browser - you should see all devices on your network!

■ Common Problems & Solutions

Problem	Solution
Web page won't load	1. Check your Pi's IP with: <code>hostname -I</code> 2. Make sure you typed <code>http://</code> before the IP 3. Try <code>http://YOUR-IP</code> without <code>/pialert/</code> 4. Restart Apache: <code>sudo systemctl restart apache2</code>
Page loads but no devices showing	1. Wait 5 minutes for first scan 2. Run manual scan (see Step 9) 3. Check if other devices are actually on your network
Permission denied errors	Run these again: <code>sudo chown -R www-data:www-data /var/www/html/pialert</code> <code>sudo chmod -R 755 /var/www/html/pialert</code>
arp-scan errors	Double-check Step 6. Make sure you added the line exactly: <code>www-data ALL=(ALL) NOPASSWD: /usr/sbin/arp-scan</code>
Installer failed	Try running it again: <code>cd /var/www/html/pialert</code> <code>sudo ./install/pialert_install.sh</code>

■ Using Pi Alert

Understanding the Dashboard

- **Online** - Devices currently connected
- **Down** - Devices that were connected but aren't now
- **All** - Every device that has ever connected

Customizing Device Names

Click on any device to give it a friendly name! Instead of seeing 'Unknown-AA:BB:CC:DD:EE:FF', you can name it 'Mom's iPhone' or 'Living Room TV'.

Setting Up Alerts

Click on a device, then toggle the bell icon to get notified when it connects. Great for knowing when kids come home or if an unknown device joins your network!

■ *TIP: Pi Alert scans your network every 5 minutes by default. You can change this in the settings if you want.*

■ Quick Command Reference

Task	Command
Access Pi Alert	Open browser: http://YOUR-PI-IP/pialert/
Run manual scan	<pre>cd /var/www/html/pialert sudo php back/pialert.php 1 updateDevices</pre>
Find Pi's IP	<pre>hostname -I</pre>
Restart web server	<pre>sudo systemctl restart apache2</pre>
Check if Apache is running	<pre>sudo systemctl status apache2</pre>
View Pi Alert logs	<pre>sudo tail /var/www/html/pialert/log/pialert.log</pre>
Restart your Pi	<pre>sudo reboot</pre>

■ What's Next?

Once you're comfortable with basic Pi Alert, you can explore:

- Setting up email notifications for alerts
- Integrating with Pi-hole for ad blocking
- Creating custom device groups
- Setting up remote access to your Pi Alert



■ **Setup Complete!**

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